

THE WHOLE-STEP RULE

How to find available tensions on ANY diatonic chord — one rule, infinite application.

THE RULE

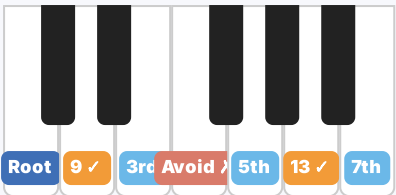
Look at the notes in the key that are **NOT part of the chord**. Ask: is each note a **WHOLE STEP** or **HALF STEP** above the nearest chord tone?

Whole step = Available Tension ✓ Half step = Avoid Note ✗

WORKED EXAMPLE — IMAJ7 IN C MAJOR (CMAJ7)

STEP 1 — FIND CHORD TONES VS NON-CHORD TONES

C major scale: C D E F G A B. Cmaj7 chord tones: C · E · G · B. Non-chord tones (scale notes NOT in chord): D · F · A



STEP 2 — APPLY THE WHOLE-STEP TEST

D	→ C (root) → C# → D = WHOLE step above C (root)	9 — Available ✓
F	→ E (3rd) → F = HALF step above E (3rd). No black key between E and F.	4 — Avoid ✗
A	→ G (5th) → G# → A = WHOLE step above G (5th)	13 — Available ✓

AVAILABLE TENSIONS PER DIATONIC CHORD — C MAJOR

CHORD	ROMAN NUMERAL	FUNCTION	AVAILABLE TENSIONS	NOTES
Cmaj7	I maj7	Tonic	9 13	F (4th/11th) is avoid — half step above E (3rd)
Dm7	ii-7	Subdominant	9 11	13 conditional — can steal the ii- V voice leading momentum
Em7	iii-7	Tonic	11	b9 (F) and b13 (C) both fail the test — half step above chord tones
Fmaj7	IV maj7	Subdominant	9 #11 13	All 3 pass; #11 creates pensive tritone with root F
G7	V7	Dominant	9 13	C (4th) is avoid; dominant chords can accept more tensions (advanced topic)
Am7	vi-7	Tonic	9 11	b6 (F) would alter chord quality — not a tension, it changes the chord
Bø7	viiø7	Dominant	11 b13	Most sophisticated diatonic chord; 11 is the most common tension to add